Corner, Interview with a Policeman and Crayon Wars

By Ralph Pomeroy, Ai and Jackie Sheeler

INTRODUCTION

Just as all parents broach sensitive topics with their children like AIDS and sexuality or drug use, black parents say they talk to their children about dealing with the police. It is just a matter of time, they tell them, before they encounter a police officer who sees dark skin as synonymous with crime. They coach them on how to behave: don't hang out in crowds, be polite, don't make any sudden moves, carry identification, ask to make a phone call, refuse to answer incriminating questions. It is a task they find unpleasant but necessary as their children start to venture out onto the streets alone, a way to cushion the emotional trauma that comes with discrimination. Corner by Ralph Pomeroy.

Corner

The cop slumps alertly at his motorcycle,
supported by one leg like a leather stork.
His glance accuses me of loitering.
I can see his eyes moving like a fish
in the green depths of his green goggles.

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His ease is fake. I can tell.
My ease is fake. And he can tell.
The fingers armoured by his gloves
Splay and clench, itching to change something.
As if he were my enemy or my death,
I just stand there watching.

I spit out my gum which has gone stale.
I knock out my new cigarette --
Which is my bravery.
It is all imperceptible:
The way I shift my weight,
The way he creaks in the saddle.

The traffic is specific though constant.
The sun surrounds me, divides the street between us.
His crash helmet is whiter in the shade.
It is like a bullring as they say it is just before the fighting.
I cannot back down. I am there.

Everything holds me back.
I am in danger of disappearing into the sunny dust,
My levis bake and my T-shirt sweats.

My cigarette makes my eyes burn.
But I don't dare drop it.

Who made him my enemy?
Prince of coolness. King of fear.
Why do I lean here waiting?

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Why does he lounge there watching?

I am becoming sunlight.
My hair is on fire. My boots run like tar.
I am hung-up by the bright air.

Something breaks through all of a sudden.
And he blasts off, quick as a craver,
Snug in his power; watching me watch.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ralph Pomeroy
Book: Off the Cuffs
ISBN: 978-1887128810
Publisher: Soft Skull Press
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

TRANSITION

A POLICE RADIO: UNIT 412 – Respond to 115 Broadway – Allen's Liquor – Robbery in progress.

African American perpetrator, Caucasian police officer. Shots are fired and a man lies dead. Reporters swarm the scene, clamoring for interviews. . . Perpetrator . . . Victim . . . Black . . . White . . . The truth swirls into shades of gray during Ai's Interview with a Policeman.

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Interview with a Policeman

You say you want this story

in my own words,
but you won't tell it my way.
Reporters never do.
If everybody's racist,
that means you too.
I grab your finger
as you jab it at my chest.
So what, the minicam caught that?
You want to know all about it, right? —
the liquor store, the black kid
who pulled his gun
at the wrong time.
You saw the dollars he fell on and bloodied.
Remember how cold it was that night,
but I was sweating.
I'd worked hard, I was through
for twenty-four hours,
and I wanted some brew.
When I heard a shout,
I turned and saw the clerk with his hands in the air,
saw the kid drop his gun
as I yelled and ran from the back.
I only fired when he bent down,
picked up his gun, and again dropped it.
I saw he was terrified,
saw his shoulder and head jerk to the side
as the next bullet hit.

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When I dove down he got his gun once more
and fired wildly.
Liquor poured onto the counter, the floor
onto which he fell back finally,
still firing now toward the door,
when his arm flung itself behind him.
As I crawled toward him,
I could hear dance music
over the sound of liquor spilling and spilling,
and when I balanced on my hands
and stared at him, a cough or spasm
sent a stream of blood out of his mouth
that hit me in the face.

Later, I felt as if I'd left part of myself
stranded on that other side,
where anyplace you turn down,
is out for money, for drugs,
or just for something new like shoes
or sunglasses,
where your own rage
destroys everything in its wake,
including you.
Especially you.
Go on, set your pad and pencil down,
turn off the camera, the tape.
The ape in the gilded cage
looks too familiar, doesn't he,
and underneath it all,
like me, you just want to forget him.
Tonight, though, for a while you'll lie awake.

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You'll hear the sound of gunshots
in someone else's neighborhood,
then, comforted, turn over in your bed
and close your eyes,
but the boy like a shark redeemed at last
yet unrepentatant
will reenter your life
by the unlocked door of sleep
to take everything but his fury back.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ai
Book: Vice: New and Selected Poems
ISBN: 978-0393320183
Publisher: Norton, W. W. & Company, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): June 2000

TRANSITION

Jackie Sheeler draws the lines of battle between police and minorities in terms of Crayola Wars.

CRAYOLA WARS

The color of the body
has been at the beginning
of far too many wars

and misunderstandings. I would never be
shot down 41 times in some hallway

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by men with eyes as blue

as my own handsome cop-daddy's eyes
because my body is the color of protection.
Every day I strut past the target-practice hearts of the police

holding court on the street, and I'm never afraid.
I have lived among badges all my life
growing numb, going blind to the uniforms.

Darken me into cowardice, then:
tan me black, fill
in between my lines with Burnt Siena

the best of all those good Crayola names
the blackest of the browns
more certain than Raw Umber to result

in frequent frisks and eventual capture
in this grown-up game of cops and maybe
robbers
where the cap guns always malfunction

and bang bang you're dead

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is written in blood the color of tenement brick
drying on the stoops of certain neighbors.

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Author: Jackie Sheeler
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